

eg update

送信者: Ian Bremmer 受信日時: 2026-09-21 20:53

【メール原文】

dear hondo-san, global actors in a new world order. no ai slowdown. how to end the iran war. the canada-eu relationship. and a deal on greenland. navigating the g-zero

||

dear hondo-san,

global actors in a new world order. no ai slowdown. how to end the iran war. the canada-eu relationship. and a deal on greenland.

navigating the g-zero world

it's the most uncertain global environment we've experienced in generations. the old rules of the road no longer apply: it's no longer a world of us-led globalization, that order isn't coming back. what's coming next isn't clear yet. which begs the macro question—what to do in the face of such uncertainty?

let's start with the geopolitics. there are three changes in the core balance of power that got us here. 1) post-soviet russia wasn't integrated into the then-dominant west (nato/eu/g7) and blames the united states and europe for this. putin's russia has accordingly become a revisionist, and risk acceptant, rogue state. 2) china has been integrated into the broader western-led global economy on the presumption that they would align their political and economic systems with those of the west. china has now become the second most powerful country in the world (and the dominant trade and diplomatic partner for most of the global south) but has only further consolidated their authoritarian political system and state capitalist economy. and 3) the united states no longer embraces global leadership on collective security, free trade, or the promotion of democracy and the rule of law.

nearly all international actors are uneasy about the unpredictability and unreliability of the g-zero world (to be sure, a few see pure upside in the breakdown—former pariahs who now have more space to operate, like north korea or the houthis in yemen). but countries are coming to different conclusions on which changes to the balance of power matter most and, accordingly, behaving with different motivations. for ukraine and front-line nato states, russia is the principal destabilizer and most urgent concern. talking with ukrainian leadership in the past days, they were quick to reassure an american: “we’re good with the united states now”—which isn’t strictly speaking true (they’d like far more alignment on policy, not to mention economic and military support), but the point is that ukraine is much more flexible in what they’ll accept from washington given their security concerns from moscow. in canada, prime minister mark carney has said his country is “at war” with the united states, and while it’s nothing close to the existential threat that the russians pose to kyiv, it’s by far the biggest challenge for ottawa, and informs a middle powers strategy that prioritizes a strategic realignment toward the european union (the “middle power” with the strongest economic weight vis-à-vis the americans) but also greater diversification toward other trading partners—including china. for japan, south korea, and australia, china’s rise and increasing assertiveness as an economic, technology, and regional security leader is the most important g-zero challenge—hence, for example, japan’s and south korea’s urgency in moving forward on hundreds of billions of investment commitments to the americans that they privately consider extortionate.

much of this is geographic, which is unsurprising given the way much economic trade, diplomatic influence, and security footprint diffuses over distance. but proximity isn't a full proxy—for israel, changes in policy of a very distant ally in the united states remain the most important driver; brazil's lack of international security priority and alignment makes it more divided in responding to changes from the united states and china, despite its position in an otherwise more us-dominant western hemisphere.

these competing geopolitical realities constrain the ability and willingness of countries to build a post g-zero global order, leading to a period of greater fragmentation. and so, while we should expect to see new alliances and alignments emerge from the g-zero, that's principally going to come from a variety of regional and thematic mini-lateral arrangements (some of which will be directly competitive and even adversarial, but most of which will just be different), as opposed to efforts to reform or build new global architecture. as for the latter—whether a more fit-for-purpose united nations; a global governance structure for climate or artificial intelligence; or a new global alternative to the united states-led economic system in the brics—these are the areas to be most skeptical of.

that's the geopolitics. but what about the global economy?

here, there's less uncertainty than you'd think. yes, the united states has shifted from the world's driver of free trade to a more transactional, zero-sum set of industrial policies, tariffs, and subsidies; many of which other countries perceive as weaponization of the dollar and us dominant financial architecture. but overall international trade as a percentage of global gdp has remained reasonably constant over the course of the last two decades.

there are a few reasons for this. first, the actual growth in tariff levels from the united states has been considerably lower than the headline numbers announced—a combination of negotiation (through both inducements and threats) with other countries, us domestic pushback from affected economic actors with political clout, and legal constraints from the us judiciary. second, the us economy remains the world's largest market, outstripping other advanced industrial democracies in growth and productivity; and while china is more attractive on those measures, it remains less so in terms of lack of transparency, absence of rule of law/independent judiciary, and level of state control. all of which makes china a more problematic pivot for those concerned about changes in the united states. third, despite a growth in protectionism around key commodities and in strategic sectors; most of the hedging away from the united states is not shifting toward domestic investment, as there remains comparative advantage in nearly every sector and good from international trade flows. and fourth, the growth of the digital economy means that global expansion of markets through improved access to labor and data has brought down barriers for international trade even as domestic policies have increased trade friction. globalization—the increasing flow of goods, people, capital, and ideas across borders—is no longer being driven by the united states, but it's more usefully described as now leaderless and rudderless than actively being brought to a close.

on new technology, two major trends cut in opposite directions.

post-carbon global energy is increasingly dominated by china, which for decades has invested in the technologies and the critical mineral and rare earth supply chains to power them. china is now the world's first electrostate (as we wrote in this year's top risks: "overpowered"), with more near-term influence over states reliant for inexpensive access accordingly (including, by the way, the united states). but electrons are harder to durably ring-fence than carbon, which makes this a short-term game. long term, global energy is becoming decentralized, with no country or countries dominant (as

we see with the unwind of opec), leading to greater local production that reflects a more multipolar economy.

artificial intelligence, on the other hand, is presently dominated by the united states and china. both countries are prioritizing ensuring that as many other countries as possible choose their preferred tech stack, with the national security subordination, economic integration, and diplomatic alignment that comes as a consequence. unlike global trade and energy, ai development increasingly appears to be a core component of the national security strategies of the united states and china—hence president trump’s statement last week that “who wins ai, wins”; and china’s security outline on the essential importance of the uncontested control of ai by the chinese communist party.

ai is quickly taking on the characteristics of a cold war—which would make this week’s trump-xi meeting on the topic essential, aside from the fact that both are presently prioritizing avoiding making short-term waves on the topic. still, looking ahead even a year, i see the geopolitics of ai being the most adversarial to the creation of a new, post g-zero global order—even as the risks and opportunities attendant with artificial intelligence make the urgency of a new order greater.

ai at speed

there's all sorts of talk of a slowdown—I can't remember ever seeing the dominant companies in a space, never mind a space that's driving the growth of the us and global economy, saying we really need to take it easier. but whether from the ai corporate leaders, us government, or the chinese communist party, i don't see any such thing even beginning to happen.

anthropic ceo dario amodei's voluntary offer is welcome: giving outside experts employee-level access to assess potential dangers from frontier models and raise their concerns. it's certainly preferable to releasing frontier models first and having the us government shut you down when dangerous capabilities become apparent (as occurred this spring with mythos).

but the rest of anthropic's calls for "pacing the frontier" require coordination with other technology companies. which isn't going to happen for three reasons: 1) other firms aren't prepared to go along with it (nvidia and meta openly oppose; while openai and spacexai's public head nodding is at least in part about showing they're on the right side with an increasingly animated and skeptical american public); 2) president trump has zero willingness to provide a legislative solution, and voluntary alignment falls afoul of antitrust law absent that; and 3) china's response is that this is an effort to handcuff china's own ai efforts to build their economy and national security (and not in that order), which they'll have no part of. absent that, and with neither trust nor useful dialogue between the two countries on the issue, the probability that the united states will voluntarily move in this direction is close to zero.

you might think the openai huggingface incident would be sufficient to change minds in the government on this front...but you'd be wrong. a warning signal that wasn't a crisis, for president trump—who won't listen to advisers (secretary of treasury scott bessent had pushed for finra-type institution and trump shot it down)—wasn't going to move the needle. i'm not sure a bigger crisis would change matters, at least not presently: president trump's orientation is keep the ai market boom going, with self-regulation by individual companies (that, as i'm saying, won't go anywhere given the competitive domestic and international environment) coupled with executive authority and no regulation in response to crises when they occur (which will necessarily be backward looking, preferential, and narrow).

i've written in past months that i think we've passed peak trump in terms of the ability of the american president to drive disruption—and we see more datapoints on that front daily, whether the supreme court voting down the mail in ballot effort, the coming midterm election expectations, the inability to determine core outcomes in a growing number of geopolitical matters, and the like. i still hold to that view.

but artificial intelligence increasingly looks like an important outlier here: two years plus of an american president who defines ai risk as a hoax alongside climate change, who steadfastly refuses to consider what proactive governance might be necessary to avoid a dangerous crisis...at a time when ai is accelerating well beyond the ability of the principal ai owners to define and contain vectors of downside...is the most meaningful risk presented by the second half of the trump administration.

ending the iran war?

in last week's update i noted that i'm less concerned about escalation between iran and the united states than i am between russia and ukraine (and between russia and nato, for that matter). but that also begs the question, especially as the costs pile up: how do we eventually bring the fighting in the middle east to an end?

at the brics summit a week ago, the issue was on everyone's mind. india was able to bring the iranian president and the uae prime minister together for their first meeting since the war started; and prime minister narendra modi expressed his country's willingness to facilitate ongoing negotiations. china too said they were prepared to play a role to help bring the war to an end; president xi jinping used the summit stage to call for a collective brics role to that end. and both leaders worked hard to get mention of the war into the summit's delhi communique—limited to criticism of strikes on hezbollah and internationally-monitored nuclear sites in iran, but nonetheless significant given that brics membership and associate membership includes direct antagonists in the iran war. the gulf states increasingly welcome the help on the diplomatic front; while the chinese and the indians, like most everyone else, are taking considerable economic pain (and domestic dissatisfaction, however differently expressed) on account of a war that they didn't start and have no interest in.

but absent a willingness of the iranians to cut a deal that the americans will accept (and vice versa), there's not much point to the engagement. and that still has months to play out. breaking the impasse is more about the economic pressure that will continue to build on the united states—and that remains further away from making a difference than you might think. the white house has been consistently surprised that oil prices aren't higher: they've had internal briefs projecting we would be at \$150 months ago, and ever since the blockade was put into place were prepared for oil at \$120+. further, president trump and the core cabinet no longer believe the iranians are about to buckle under pressure...so they understand (even if they don't quite accept) that there's no near-term fix. which helps explain why trump has recently been saying nothing is likely to happen until after the us midterms in november.

two things to watch after that. first, the willingness of president trump to order further military escalation eventually increases. again, not so much that critical infrastructure across the region is threatened, but with the intention of putting more constraints on iran. second, iran's control over the strait is a wasting resource—their recent strikes on the saudi east-west pipeline (from irgc controlled militias in iraq) came because the united states was able to get more oil through the strait of hormuz despite iranian threats. iran understands that coercion will get them less if it persists for years. so eventually, the "price discovery" as i called it last week, becomes clearer to all involved. and the united

states will become less uncomfortable with a deal that is struck and directly paid by gulf states (especially against a backdrop where the economic costs of the war are only mounting) and trump announces a "win" on "ending" nuclear capabilities for iran (that's weaker than the obama deal, with major economic costs) and packs up.

at that point, the gulf states announce a deal. and, indeed, china and india are likely to play a constructive role. if i had to guess, i'd say no earlier than the first or second quarter of next year. but we aren't there yet.

canada-eu

and then a historic first, canadian prime minister mark carney invited by european union president ursula von der leyen to become an associate member of europe. never mind there's no mechanism yet in place for such a formulation, nor that carney isn't looking to join the eu. it's a significant step forward, borne of mutual concerns of the unpredictability and unreliability of a core ally, the united states; while the chinese aren't remotely a replacement option.

carney's hope is to build something with europe that's stronger than an alliance (something like a "bloc" agreement), that could explicitly act as a model to welcome other countries (the united kingdom, australia, and more) to follow canada's lead. with the idea being less about aligning with european laws and regulations, and rather to more closely integrate in areas where canada's "strategic pillars"—critical minerals, energy security, technology/research, defense, and more—and europe's scale can create strength and resilience in a more unstable and adversarial geopolitical environment.

president trump quickly said he opposed the move and would cut off trade with the europeans if any agreement threatened the united states. but that's not so different than the threats he made against spain in the latest nato summit (that were ignored), or against the nordics during the greenland flap back in january (that trump reversed within days). not much to see on that front. but the shift of canada toward a more diversified set of trade, diplomatic, and security relationships will persist; and while the next us president, democratic or republican, will move to repair the damage, the nature of the us-canada alliance won't return to what it was.

*

and after nearly a year of tension, this weekend president trump announced a deal with denmark and greenland. i've spoken with several nordic/european leaders who are extremely pleased/relieved with the outcome, with the us president having backed away from all of the danes' red lines on territory and sovereignty...and the europeans not wanting to say anything to contradict his "greatest deal ever" rhetoric so that trump actually signs the deal this week. from the white house perspective, the greenland policy was among trump's most unpopular (-40%, compared to -38% on the epstein files), even if not particularly consequential, so getting it off the agenda and claiming victory is welcome, especially before midterms. another datapoint for my view that we're now past peak trump.

it's unga week—the busiest of the year in new york city. the festivities really kicked off yesterday, if i'm being honest...and now all sorts of events, bilaterals, and policy engagements over the course of the week. will look forward to reporting back next monday...

with best wishes,

ian

© 2026 Eurasia Group. All rights reserved. This material was produced by Eurasia Group for use by the recipient. This is intended as general background research and is not intended to constitute advice on any particular commercial investment or trade matter or issue and should not be relied upon for such purposes. It is not to be made available to any person other than the recipient. No part of this publication may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic or otherwise, without the prior consent of Eurasia Group.

X-HG-DocID cmub5xpuy2lwt07n7mvh5j3v5

[PDF](#) | [Opt Out](#) | [Customize Email Preferences](#)